

Advocacy Pitch

A Pitch to Senator John Cornyn on School Library Funding for Digital Literacy Initiatives

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Hello,

My name is Amanda Clark, and I am a member of the Georgetown, Texas community. My children attend school in the Liberty Hill Independent School District (LHISD) at Rancho Sienna Elementary School and Santa Rita Middle School. LHISD is considered a fast growth district in Central Texas, and it currently serves a student population of over 10,000 students. Travis Motal, our Interim Superintendent, has stated that he expects this growth to continue and that the district has averaged approximately 12% to 15% more students each year in the last few years. The growth of our student population is not the only type of growth we are seeing in the area. We are also experiencing rapid commercial growth and sustained corporate expansions in the technology industry with companies like Apple, Samsung, Tesla, and an influx of technology startups in the region. Our student population deserves access to local job markets in every industry including technology, and our school libraries are where this process begins. Libraries provide access not only to books but also to technology, research support, and the foundational digital skills that students increasingly need to succeed in current and future job markets.

I'm here to talk to you about the importance of expanding digital literacy programming in public school libraries through flexible federal funding. Knowing of your interest in STEM education, workforce readiness, and your legislative efforts to eliminate the digital divide and provide greater access to the internet, I thought you would be particularly interested in how school libraries can build on the momentum you've created. Recent research into savvy digital citizenship has shown that effective interventions, like teaching a strategy called lateral reading, can significantly improve the ability our students have to judge the credibility of online sources of information (Wineburg et al., 2022).

Over the last decade, Sam Wineburg and his colleagues at Stanford University and the University of Maryland, College Park have investigated the unique digital challenges that this generation of students

are facing. Other leaders in education concur. For instance, Dr. Gloria Mark has been pointing out the relentless assault on attention, the significant drop in a student's ability to maintain focus, and the constant interruption that digital overload creates. Dr. Mark also discusses how rising rates of anxiety and depression may be related to our digital activities (Mark, 2023). Given all these difficulties, Wineburg partnered with several foundations that provided research grants to study young people's ability to effectively and quickly evaluate online content (Digital Inquiry Group, n.d.). If we can reduce the amount of time a student needs to make informed decisions about the credibility of online resources, then we can have a positive impact on student outcomes.

In the spring of 2019, Wineburg partnered with an urban school district to perform a district-wide field study on the effects of the lateral reading intervention in high school government classes. Teachers in the district were trained to deliver six 50-minute lessons where students learned how to execute the lateral reading strategy. They were taught how to leave websites they were unfamiliar with to investigate the credibility of the source before spending too much time and attention on a website produced by a source that may be less than credible. The results of this study showed that students who were given the chance to practice lateral reading were better able to judge the credibility of digital content than peers who had not received the same digital literacy instruction. In fact, prior to the delivery of this instruction, "only three in more than 3,000 – less than one tenth of one percent" were able to successfully evaluate the credibility of the source of an online video. Following the instruction, students nearly doubled their ability to verify the source from pre- to posttest (Wineburg et al., 2022).

This effort to teach students to authenticate online information by first establishing the credentials of an online source came to be known as "Civic Online Reasoning." Starting in the fall of 2026, the State University of New York (SUNY) will be adding digital literacy requirements to their core coursework that helps students apply responsible and ethical judgement to the use of AI-driven sources

of information. However, Wineburg believes that “without already excelling at those skills, students who move on to postsecondary studies are doomed to fall for generative AI ‘hallucinations,’ a term for when technology spits out entirely made-up information as if it were true” (Alonso, 2025). We have the opportunity in public school libraries to intervene before students face the pressure to perform and wind up defaulting to inaccurate AI outputs. We are the custodians of our own integrity but without teaching students these lessons, how can we ask them to uphold the ethical expectations we’ve set for them?

This is important to the people I represent because cultivating digital fluency enhances our students’ abilities to succeed not only in higher education but also in their everyday lives. Implementing digital literacy initiatives will:

- introduce modern critical thinking skills
- lead to a fuller STEM education that makes lessons in digital citizenship actionable
- prepare our workforce to evaluate information quickly
- allow our workforce to tackle professional hurdles in a more productive manner
- promote ethical online civic engagement and community vitality
- help to bridge the technology gap and the digital divide
- empower students to protect their personal interests
- improve communication and collaboration

Digital literacy is no longer optional. As SUNY has asserted, it is a core competency for a well-rounded student because it is a critical workforce skill. In communities like LHISD, school libraries are uniquely positioned to deliver lessons in digital literacy to a wide range of student groups. When students gain these skills under the wider umbrella of information literacy, they enter the workforce prepared for the challenges a digital world presents. They will be more equipped to support themselves and the long-term economic growth of Texas.

These are the reasons I really hope you will support federal funding for digital literacy initiatives in public school libraries. Cultivating digital fluency in young people requires the type of sustained instruction librarians are trained to provide given their background in information literacy pedagogy. With this funding, public school librarians will gain insights into modern digital literacy curriculums and will be able to leverage their foundational expertise in information literacy instruction, ethical research, and inquiry-based learning strategies. Students will receive guided, scaffolded, and purposeful instruction that will foster digital curiosity and gradual competency. Expanding specific funding for digital literacy programming while simultaneously allowing Texas schools to flexibly determine how best to implement the funding in each district will allow district librarians to tailor access to technology to their unique student needs. It will enhance digital citizenship, improve collaboration and communication, and it will boost the ability of our future workforce to succeed in a competitive market environment.

Will you be willing to support or recommend a grant-based funding opportunity that will provide librarians with the resources needed to improve digital literacy and empower students to succeed in a digital workforce?

Follow-Up Email

Dear Senator Cornyn and Staff,

Thank you for taking the time to meet with me to discuss digital literacy programming in Texas' public-school libraries. I appreciated the opportunity to share my perspective as a member of the Liberty Hill ISD community. I'd like to follow-up by asking for an update on the status of my request for support in securing grant-based funding to expand digital literacy programming that can be tailored to meet the specific needs of each district and student population. Research and program outcomes from across the country continue to show that structured digital literacy instruction improves student outcomes. School

libraries are especially well-positioned to deliver this kind of instruction. If it would be helpful, I would be glad to provide additional research and materials on the topic, including examples of digital literacy programs that have proven successful in other K-12 settings.

Thank you again for your time and consideration. I appreciate your commitment to the people of Texas and the student communities in need of your ongoing support. I hope to stay in touch.

Sincerely,

Amanda Clark

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